

"From Listener to Ally" - Branching Scenario

SCENARIO CHARTER

Problem Statement:

In a team meeting, Sam notices their colleague Yuki's idea being overlooked and later adopted by someone else without credit. Sam wants to practice allyship but isn't sure how to intervene without making Yuki uncomfortable or creating conflict.

Learning Objective:

By the end of this scenario, learners will practice intervening when a colleague's voice is overlooked, amplifying contributions using respectful language, and avoiding language that draws unwanted attention.

Success Signal:

Learner can identify moments requiring allyship, select effective amplification phrases, and understand the difference between supportive intervention and performative or uncomfortable spotlight.

Context:

Sam is part of a diverse marketing team. In today's virtual meeting, Yuki (a quieter, thoughtful contributor) suggests a creative campaign direction that gets briefly acknowledged but not discussed. Ten minutes later, Marcus presents a similar idea and the team enthusiastically engages. Yuki stops contributing. Sam must decide how to act as an ally.

FULL BRANCHING SCRIPT WITH DECISIONS

SLIDE 1: INTRODUCTION (Situation Setup)

Title: A Moment for Allyship

Narration/Text:

"You're Sam, a marketing specialist on a multicultural team. Today's virtual brainstorming session is focused on a new product launch campaign.

About 15 minutes in, your colleague Yuki suggests: 'What if we created a user-generated content campaign where customers share their own stories?'

Your manager, Lisa, responds briefly: 'Interesting thought,' and moves on to ask for other ideas.

Ten minutes later, Marcus says: 'I think we should build the campaign around authentic customer stories—maybe even user-generated content.'

Lisa lights up: 'Oh, I love that! Yes, authentic voices. Let's explore that direction. Great thinking, Marcus.'

You notice Yuki has turned off their camera. For the rest of the meeting, they don't offer any more ideas.

You realize Yuki's contribution was overlooked, and now Marcus is getting credit for essentially the same idea."

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 2

SLIDE 2: DECISION POINT 1 - Recognizing the Need for Allyship

Title: What do you do in this moment?

Prompt: "The meeting is still ongoing. How do you respond to what just happened?"

OPTIONS:

A) "Stay silent. Maybe Yuki doesn't mind, and you don't want to make things awkward."

B) "Speak up immediately: 'Actually, that's exactly what Yuki suggested 10 minutes ago. Marcus, did you get that idea from Yuki?'"

C) "Wait for an appropriate moment and say: 'I think what Marcus is describing builds really well on what Yuki mentioned earlier about user-generated content. Maybe we can explore both angles?'"

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 3A
 - Option B → Slide 3B
 - Option C → Slide 3C
-

SLIDE 3A: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

The meeting continues. Marcus's idea gains momentum and becomes the campaign direction.

After the meeting ends, you send Yuki a private message: "That was your idea! I can't believe they gave Marcus credit."

Yuki replies: "Yeah, it happens. Thanks for noticing though."

Over the next few weeks, you notice Yuki contributing less in meetings. Their energy seems different.

Feedback to Learner:

✗ Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

While staying silent might feel "safe," silence can actually reinforce exclusion. Your private message to Yuki afterward doesn't undo the public erasure of their contribution. Yuki needed an ally in the moment, not sympathy afterward.

Reflection Prompt:

What message does silence send to the team? How might Yuki feel knowing you noticed but didn't speak up?

Cultural Insight:

In many cultures, speaking up assertively in meetings isn't comfortable or expected. When quieter voices are consistently overlooked, they stop contributing—and the team loses valuable perspectives and innovation.

Relationship Note:

Trust is missed. Yuki feels unsupported. The team's culture of psychological safety weakens.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 2 OR [Continue to Resolution] → Slide 4

SLIDE 3B: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

The meeting goes silent. Marcus looks defensive: "What? No, I was just building on the conversation."

Lisa jumps in: "Let's not get sidetracked. We're all contributing here."

Yuki turns their camera back on briefly, looking uncomfortable, then quickly says: "It's fine. Let's just keep going."

The meeting ends awkwardly. Afterward, Yuki messages you privately: "Thanks for trying to help, but that was really embarrassing."

Feedback to Learner:

✗ Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

Your intention was good, but the execution created discomfort rather than support. Directly accusing Marcus put everyone on the defensive and spotlighted Yuki in an uncomfortable way. This approach felt confrontational, not collaborative.

Reflection Prompt:

How did your phrasing create conflict rather than clarity? What impact did this have on Yuki, who you were trying to help?

Cultural Insight:

Aggressive allyship can feel performative and make the person you're trying to support more uncomfortable. Effective allyship redirects attention without assigning blame.

Relationship Note:

Trust is damaged with both Yuki (who felt embarrassed) and Marcus (who felt attacked). The team dynamic is strained.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 2 OR [Continue] → Slide 4

SLIDE 3C: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Lisa pauses: "Oh, you're right Sam. Yuki, you did mention user-generated content earlier. Marcus, you're adding the authentic storytelling angle. Let's make sure we're building on both ideas."

Yuki turns their camera back on and nods: "Yeah, I was thinking specifically about a hashtag campaign where customers share video testimonials."

Lisa: "I love it. Yuki, can you lead the research on platform options for this? Marcus, can you explore the storytelling framework?"

The conversation continues collaboratively. After the meeting, Yuki messages you: "Thanks for that. I appreciated you catching it."

Feedback to Learner:

 **Correct Choice - Effective Allyship**

Why this works:

You practiced effective allyship by:

- **Intervening without confrontation:** "builds really well on"
- **Redirecting credit:** Named Yuki's original contribution
- **Staying collaborative:** Framed it as exploring "both angles," not assigning blame
- **Timing:** Spoke up in the moment when it mattered

This approach gave Yuki's voice visibility without putting them on the spot or creating defensiveness.

Reflection Prompt:

How did framing both contributions as valuable ("build on both") maintain psychological safety while ensuring proper credit?

Cultural Insight:

Effective allyship in multicultural teams means noticing different communication styles and creating space without forcing spotlight. You honored Yuki's quieter style while ensuring their idea was recognized.

Relationship Note:

Trust is strengthened. Yuki feels supported. The team sees modeling of inclusive behavior.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 4

SLIDE 4: DECISION POINT 2 - Amplifying in Real Time

Title: Later in the same meeting

Context Text:

"The meeting continues. Lisa asks: 'Any other thoughts on messaging strategy?'"

You notice Yuki has started to type something in the chat but then deletes it. Their camera is still on, but they look hesitant."

Prompt: "How do you create space for Yuki to contribute?"

OPTIONS:

- A) "Say: 'Yuki, you always have great insights on messaging. What are you thinking?'"
- B) "Say: 'I notice the chat is quiet. For anyone who's been thinking and wants to share, we'd love to hear your perspective.'"
- C) "Say: 'Yuki, you haven't said much. What's going on? Do you have thoughts on this?'"

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 5A
 - Option B → Slide 5B
 - Option C → Slide 5C
-

SLIDE 5A: Consequence + Feedback (PARTIAL)

Dialogue Outcome:

Yuki looks a bit surprised but responds: "Um, I was thinking about how we position the emotional benefit versus the functional benefit."

Lisa: "Good point. Let's explore that."

The conversation continues. Afterward, Yuki doesn't message you, but they seem okay.

Feedback to Learner:

 **Partially Correct**

Why this could be better:

While you successfully amplified Yuki's voice, directly calling on them by name put them on the spot. This can work when you're certain someone wants to contribute, but it can also create pressure. The compliment ("you always have great insights") was nice but might feel like added pressure to perform.

Reflection Prompt:

How might being called on by name feel different in various cultures? When is it appropriate versus potentially uncomfortable?

Cultural Insight:

In some cultures, being singled out—even with praise—can feel uncomfortable. It's important to know your colleagues' preferences before using this approach.

Relationship Note:

Trust is maintained. Yuki contributed but may have preferred a less direct invitation.

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SLIDE 5B: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

After a brief pause, Yuki unmutes: "I was actually thinking about the emotional versus functional positioning in our messaging."

Lisa: "Yes, that's important. Say more."

Yuki shares a thoughtful analysis. Two other quieter team members also contribute ideas.

After the meeting, Yuki messages: "Thanks for creating that space. I wasn't sure if my thought was fully formed yet."

Feedback to Learner:

 **Correct Choice - Open Invitation**

Why this works:

You created space without putting anyone on the spot:

- **Inclusive language:** "anyone who's been thinking"
- **No pressure:** People can choose to contribute or not
- **Normalized thinking time:** Acknowledged that some people process before speaking
- **Multiple voices:** This approach often brings out more than one quieter contributor

This is the most respectful form of amplification—it invites without forcing.

Reflection Prompt:

How did leaving the choice with individuals create more psychological safety? What other benefits came from this approach?

Cultural Insight:

In cultures where waiting to be invited is a sign of respect, open invitations signal that contributions are welcome without creating obligation or spotlight.

Relationship Note:

Trust is significantly strengthened. Multiple team members feel safer contributing.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 6

SLIDE 5C: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Yuki looks uncomfortable: "Oh, no, I'm just listening. I don't really have anything to add right now."

The conversation moves on, but the atmosphere feels awkward. You notice Yuki turns their camera off shortly after.

Feedback to Learner:**✗ Incorrect Choice****Why this doesn't work:**

This phrasing ("you haven't said much... what's going on?") sounds accusatory or concerned rather than inviting. It puts Yuki on the spot in an uncomfortable way and implies there's something wrong with being quiet. The result: Yuki withdrew further.

Reflection Prompt:

What assumptions did this question make about Yuki? How did it create pressure rather than invitation?

Cultural Insight:

Treating quietness as a problem ("what's going on?") can make thoughtful processors feel there's something wrong with their communication style. Silence isn't always a problem to solve.

Relationship Note:

Trust is weakened. Yuki feels judged for their quieter style. They're less likely to contribute in future.

Navigation: [Try Again] → Slide 4 OR [Continue] → Slide 6

SLIDE 6: DECISION POINT 3 - Post-Meeting Follow-Up

Title: After the meeting ends

Context Text:

"The meeting has ended. You want to check in with Yuki about how the meeting went, especially since you intervened earlier on their behalf."

Prompt: "How do you follow up with Yuki?"

OPTIONS:

A) "Send a Slack message: 'Hey! I noticed your idea got overlooked earlier, so I wanted to make sure you got credit. You should speak up more confidently in meetings—your ideas are great!'"

B) "Send a Slack message: 'Hey Yuki, I thought your user-generated content idea was really strong. I'm glad we could build on it together with Marcus. How are you feeling about the direction?'"

C) "Don't send anything. You already helped during the meeting—no need to make a big deal of it."

Navigation:

- Option A → Slide 7A
 - Option B → Slide 7B
 - Option C → Slide 7C
-

SLIDE 7A: Consequence + Feedback (POOR CHOICE)**Dialogue Outcome:**

Yuki responds: "Thanks... I appreciate you noticing. I'll try."

But you sense the message didn't land well.

Feedback to Learner:

 Incorrect Choice

Why this doesn't work:

While your intention was supportive, your message:

- Made Yuki's communication style the problem ("speak up more confidently")
- Positioned you as superior ("your ideas are great" from a position of judgment)
- Potentially made Yuki feel their style is inadequate

Effective allyship doesn't ask people to change their authentic style—it creates systems where different styles are valued.

Reflection Prompt:

How did this message inadvertently blame Yuki for being overlooked? What's wrong with suggesting they "speak up more"?

Cultural Insight:

Different communication styles aren't deficiencies. Suggesting someone should "speak up more confidently" can feel dismissive of cultural norms around thoughtfulness, respect, and listening.

Relationship Note:

Trust is slightly damaged. Yuki may feel judged rather than supported.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 8

SLIDE 7B: Consequence + Feedback (BEST CHOICE)

Dialogue Outcome:

Yuki responds: "Thanks Sam. I really appreciate you connecting the ideas in the meeting. I was frustrated when it got passed over, but the way you brought it back felt natural. I'm excited about the direction—I think the video testimonial angle could be really powerful."

You continue a brief collaborative conversation about the campaign ideas.

Feedback to Learner:

 Correct Choice - Respectful Follow-Up

Why this works:

Your message:

- **Acknowledged the contribution:** Focused on the idea, not Yuki's style

- **Normalized collaboration:** "build on it together"
- **Invited perspective:** "How are you feeling about the direction?"
- **Didn't over-focus on the intervention:** Kept focus on the work

This approach maintains dignity, centers the work, and opens space for Yuki to share how they felt without forcing disclosure.

Reflection Prompt:

How did keeping focus on the idea rather than the intervention show respect for Yuki's agency?

Cultural Insight:

Respectful follow-up acknowledges what happened without making Yuki feel like a victim or problem to be solved. It maintains their professional dignity.

Relationship Note:

Trust is deepened. Yuki feels genuinely supported and valued as a collaborator.

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SLIDE 7C: Consequence + Feedback (PARTIAL)

Dialogue Outcome:

The next day, Yuki sends you a message: "Hey, thanks for catching my idea yesterday. I appreciated it."

You respond positively. The relationship continues normally.

Feedback to Learner:

 **Partially Correct**

Why this could be better:

While not harmful, skipping follow-up was a missed opportunity to:

- Reinforce that you're a reliable ally
- Learn about Yuki's experience and preferences for future allyship
- Continue building collaborative relationship

Sometimes a brief check-in strengthens the foundation you started building in the meeting.

Reflection Prompt:

What might you have learned from a brief follow-up conversation? How could that inform future allyship?

Cultural Insight:

Following up—when done thoughtfully—shows you value the person, not just the performance of allyship in front of others.

Relationship Note:

Trust is maintained but not deepened. The opportunity for relationship-building was missed.

Navigation: [Continue] → Slide 8

SLIDE 8: CONCLUSION & LEARNER TAKEAWAY

Title: What Does Allyship Look Like?

Content:

Allyship in Action:

You just practiced the essential skills of workplace allyship. Here's what makes allyship effective:

1. Intervene in Overlooked Moments

Notice when:

- Someone's idea is ignored then adopted by someone else
- A colleague is interrupted and can't finish their thought
- Quieter voices aren't being heard
- Credit is misattributed

2. Amplify Without Overstepping

Effective phrases include:

- "That builds really well on what [Name] mentioned earlier..."
- "Let's go back to [Name]'s point—I think there's something valuable there."
- "I'd love to hear the rest of what [Name] was saying."
- "That's actually similar to what [Name] suggested. Maybe we can explore both?"

3. Invite Without Forcing Spotlight

Create space without pressure:

-  "For those who've been thinking, we'd love to hear your perspective."
-  "We haven't heard from [Name] yet. Would you like to weigh in?"
-  "You've been awfully quiet. What's wrong?"
-  "Don't be scared, [Name]. Speak up!"

4. Avoid Performative Allyship

Problematic approaches:

- Making someone a "spokesperson" for their identity

- Calling people out aggressively instead of redirecting gently
- Putting people on the spot to prove you're inclusive
- Making assumptions about why someone is quiet

Key Principles:

- **Redirect, don't accuse:** "Let's build on both ideas" vs. "You stole that idea"
- **Invite, don't command:** "Would you like to share?" vs. "Tell everyone what you think"
- **Amplify, don't spotlight:** Bring attention to ideas, not to someone's difference
- **Be present, not perfect:** You won't always get it right—what matters is showing up consistently

Why This Matters:

Research shows:

- **Diverse teams are 36% more likely to outperform competitors** (McKinsey, 2020)
- **Cognitive diversity helps teams solve problems faster** (HBR, 2017)
- **Allyship helps valuable ideas stay alive and reach implementation** (Satterstrom et al., 2021)

But diversity only drives innovation when all voices are heard, valued, and credited.

Reflection Questions:

- When have you witnessed someone being overlooked? How did it feel?
- What stops you from speaking up in those moments?
- Which allyship phrases feel most authentic to your communication style?
- How might consistent allyship change your team's culture?

Next Steps:

Over the next week, practice noticing and acting:

Step 1: Notice moments when allyship is needed

- Someone interrupted
- Idea overlooked
- Quiet voice with something to share

Step 2: Practice in writing first (Slack/Teams) Use amplification language when someone's message is overlooked in digital channels

Step 3: Build to in-person/virtual meetings Try one allyship phrase in a meeting

Step 4: Reflect and adjust

- What did you say?
- How did it land?
- What would you do differently?

Remember:

You don't need to be the loudest person in the room to be an ally. You just need to listen with intention and speak up when it matters.

When you do, you're not just helping someone be heard—you're building a more inclusive, trusting, and effective team.

Navigation: [Complete] → End / LMS Tracking

CONSEQUENCE MATRIX (Quick Reference)

Decision Point	Choice A	Choice B	Choice C (Best for DP1 & DP2)
1. Recognition	Stay silent (POOR)	Accusatory confrontation (POOR)	Collaborative redirect (BEST)
Outcome	Exclusion reinforced	Defensive conflict	Credit restored
2. Amplification	Direct call-out (PARTIAL)	Open invitation (BEST)	Accusatory spotlight (POOR)
Outcome	Contribution but pressure	Multiple voices feel safe	Withdrawal/discomfort
3. Follow-up	Advice-giving (POOR)	Collaborative check-in (BEST)	No follow-up (PARTIAL)
Outcome	Style judged as problem	Trust deepened	Opportunity missed

VARIABLES & SCORING (for SCORM)

Tracking Variables:

- decision1_choice (A/B/C)
- decision2_choice (A/B/C)
- decision3_choice (A/B/C)
- total_score (calculated)

Scoring Logic:

- Best choice = 10 points

- Partial choice = 5 points
- Poor choice = 0 points

Passing Score: 20/30 (66%)

Completion Trigger: Reaching Slide 8

